

Q I'm undecided about whether or not to return to work. What should I consider?

For many families, one of the deciding factors about returning to work is the financial situation and balancing salaries with the cost of child care.

The most important thing is doing what is right for you and your partner. Both of you need to review your job circumstances, the long-term and short-term salary implications, and feelings about staying at home to make sure the appropriate person is the main caregiver. Whatever you decide, be prepared to be flexible. What you thought might work for you when you were pregnant might not turn out to be the case once your baby arrives. Well-thought out plans can change,

and you may feel you want to take a bit more time off than planned, or that an earlier return works better. If you adore being at home, then it's likely that you will find this a fulfilling option. Your feelings may change later on. You may find that you are missing your work environment and that you are eager to pursue your career. If parents are happy and fulfilled, and you feel completely comfortable with your child-care of choice, then the whole family is likely to thrive.

DISCUSSION POINTS

If you have a choice between staying at home and going back to work it's a good idea to communicate with your partner and ask yourself a few key questions:

"Will we have enough money?"

"Will the decision I make now be difficult to change?"

"How will I feel about delegating jobs to my partner and/or child-care provider?"

"Is my partner's job safe now and in the future?"

"Is my decision being affected by how I see myself and how others see me?"

"What if I miss my baby's first steps?"

"Will I find child care stimulating?"

"Will both my work and home life suffer?"

"Will I miss out on career opportunities?"

"Am I working just to pay for child care?"

Q I will be returning to work when my baby is three months old. When should I think about arranging child care?

Though your return to work may seem a long way off, and handing your baby over to a caregiver is probably the last thing you want to think about at the beginning of your maternity leave, it is definitely worth looking into this now.

You may have already given some thought at the end of pregnancy to the type of child care you would prefer—if not, start considering what you think would suit you as a family. What will your finances allow? Start making inquiries locally, look online, ask your pediatrician's office or your local government for lists of day-care centers or nannies in your area, ask parents you know for recommendations, and talk to friends with older children, who will have good advice.

Q My partner and I are thinking about dividing child care between us and another caregiver. Is this a good idea?

If you are all onboard and you are happy with your choice of child care, this can be a good solution. Often, fathers can feel regretful that they aren't spending enough time with their child, and many find that taking over one or two days a week can be extremely fulfilling. For yourself, returning to work part-time allows you to achieve a satisfactory work/life balance, and your baby gets quality time with both parents. It is worth checking that you are all following a similar nap-time and feeding routine, and that you agree on things like discipline and toilet training methods so that your baby doesn't become confused and unsure of what's expected of him.

72%

of two-parent families and **60 percent** of single mothers **work**, an increase of one-fifth since the mid-1990s.